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PERSONAL FINANCE

Irregular Income

Budget and invoice sheets



A DIGITAL GUIDE

Irregular-Income Budget + Invoice Sheets

This guide is for income that does not arrive in equal amounts: freelance deposits, commission, shifts that change, a retainer that skips a month. The average of those months is a story. The low month is the plan.

The worksheets are in this PDF. There is no spreadsheet file. Print a page or fill it on screen. This is general education. It is not tax, credit, or investment advice, and it does not promise a saved amount or a debt-free date.

> Money disclaimer. This guide is general education. It is not financial, tax, investment, or credit advice, and it is not a recommendation to buy or sell anything. Rules depend on where you live and they change. A licensed adviser where you live is the right next step for decisions that affect your taxes, your housing, or debts you cannot pay.

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01

How to use this guide

You need one real month of money in and money out, and as many earlier months as you actually have. Three to six is enough to see the shape. One month is allowed. Mark it as thin evidence. Do not invent the missing months.

• Pick one currency and write it on every total. If you mix currencies, show the rate you used.

• Round to the main unit. Precision is not the point.

• If you cannot pay minimums, stop after the debt chapter and call the lender. A worksheet is the wrong tool for that emergency.

• The invoice pages are for money you are owed. They do not create a client.

> **Try this.** Do this on a day you are not already late for a bill. A tired evening produces a hopeful baseline.

02

Why the average month lies

Add six months of deposits and divide by six. The result looks like a salary. You will spend like that salary in a month when the deposit does not come. The shortfall then looks like a character flaw. It was an arithmetic choice.

Irregular income has two different jobs. The baseline has to keep the household going in a thin month. The surplus in a thick month is not a new lifestyle. It is how the thin month gets paid for.

Number	Use it for	Do not use it for
Low month	Rent, minimums, food, the plan	Ignoring it because a better month is 'usual'
Average	Curiosity	A spending plan
High month	Filling the buffer and sinking funds	A new fixed bill

03

The low-month baseline

List the months you can document. Circle the lowest month that was a real month, not a month you were traveling on someone else's money. That number is the baseline until you have a reason, in writing, to change it.

Month	Money in	What it was

Month	Money in	What it was

If the lowest month was strange in a way you can explain, you may use the next lowest and write the reason. 'I want a nicer number' is not a reason. After two more documented months, you may rewrite the baseline. Not before.

Sort the outflows

Using the baseline, not a hopeful month, sort spending into four piles only: fixed bills, operating costs (food, transit, medicine, phone), chosen spending, and anything that actually landed in savings or a buffer. If the fixed pile is larger than the baseline, the problem is the gap. Cutting a small subscription will not close it.

04

Bills, buffer, and spending

Give the baseline jobs in this order: minimum debt payments, housing, utilities you cannot skip, food and transit, then a small chosen amount if anything remains. Savings from a baseline that does not cover food is a fiction.

A buffer is a separate balance that exists to pay the baseline in a thin month. The rule, written now: in a month above the baseline, move the extra to the buffer until the buffer holds one baseline month, or another target you wrote down. In a month below the baseline, you may move a planned amount back. You do not move it back for a want.

Account	Holds	Rule
Bills	Rent, minimums, utilities	Funded on the day money arrives
Spending	Food, transit, chosen	Only what the baseline allows
Buffer	The gap in a thin month	Filled from surplus, not from minimums

> **Try this.** If bills and spending share one balance, you will spend the electric payment. Rename the account or move the money the same day.

05

Sinking funds

A sinking fund is for a bill you can see coming: a renewal, a registration, a trip you have already decided to take, an annual tool. Divide the cost by the number of months until it is due. Move that amount from surplus first, and from the baseline only if the baseline can hold it.

Do not mix sinking funds with the buffer. December empties a buffer that was secretly a gift fund. The buffer is for the month that comes in short. The sinking fund is for the bill you named.

Bill you can see	Amount	Months until due	Set aside each month

06

Debt in one order

Pay every minimum. That is not optional. Then put extra money, when the baseline allows it, toward one balance. Avalanche means the highest interest rate first, which usually costs less over time. Snowball means the smallest balance first, which finishes an account sooner. Pick one, write the name, and do not open a new account to feel organized.

Method	Order	Watch out
Avalanche	Highest interest first	You quit because nothing finishes
Snowball	Smallest balance first	You ignore a painful rate

Account	Balance	Rate	Minimum	Extra this month

> If minimums are already impossible, contact the lender before you pay a third party to fix the debt. This is not a recommendation to take any particular loan.

07

The monthly hour

Put it on the calendar just before the payment you can most rely on, or on a fixed evening if nothing is reliable. The agenda is short so the hour does not become a mood.

- ☐ Money in since last time, by source.
- ☐ Was this month above or below the baseline?
- ☐ Buffer: what moved in or out, and did it follow the rule?
- ☐ Bills due before the next money arrives.
- ☐ Invoices sent, and invoices paid.
- ☐ Sinking funds that are short.
- ☐ One chosen expense to keep, cut, or pause.
- ☐ Stop at sixty minutes.

If you share money, do the hour together or send the one-page summary the same day. Two baselines in one household is how the buffer gets spent twice.

08

Invoices and getting paid

A budget for irregular income fails when the money you earned is still a sentence in a chat. The invoice is how the amount becomes a record. Send it when the work matches the agreement, number it, and write the due date you actually mean.

• One invoice, one scope. Do not hide a second project in the notes.

• State the currency. SAR if that is what you agreed.

• Say how they can pay you. A QR code or a link is fine. A vague 'whenever' is not.

• Follow up once, on the date you wrote, with the invoice number and the amount. Then decide whether this client is worth another job.

• When they pay, write the date on the tracker the same day, and move bill money before you decide the surplus.

Late payment is a fact about that client. It is not a reason to lower the baseline. The baseline is about the months you can document, including the late ones.

09

Invoice page

Copy this page for each bill you send. Keep a scan or the filled PDF. This is a simple invoice for your records and for the client. It is not tax advice, and it is not e-invoicing software. If you are registered for VAT where you live, follow that authority's invoice rules instead of inventing a line.

Field	Write it
Invoice number	
Date sent	
Your name	
Client	
What you delivered	
Amount and currency	
Due date	
How to pay	
Date paid	
Moved to bills or buffer?	

Payment tracker

Invoice	Client	Sent	Amount	Paid on	Days

10

When the numbers do not fit

If the fixed pile is larger than the baseline, no envelope system will invent the difference. The useful next steps are more income you can actually get, a lower fixed bill, or help from a qualified counselor. A stricter rule about small purchases will not close a housing gap.

If a high month tempts you to add a fixed payment, wait until the buffer holds the target you wrote. A new installment is how irregular income becomes a crisis with a due date.

> This guide will not tell you which fund to buy, how to file a return, or whether to refinance. Laws and products change. For a decision that could cost you a lot, hire a qualified person where you live.

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A high month, written down

Decide the split before the money arrives. A high month is any month above the baseline. The extra is not a bonus until the buffer and the sinking funds have taken the share you wrote here.

Slice of the extra	Percent or amount	Goes to
First		Buffer, until the target
Second		Sinking fund that is due soonest
Third		The one debt you named
What may be spent		Chosen spending, only after the three above

If the buffer is already full, the first slice moves to the debt or the sinking fund. It does not become a new subscription. Write the name of the account that will hold it so the transfer can happen the day the deposit clears.

A thin month, also written down

The thin month uses the buffer in a fixed order: housing and minimums first, food and transit second, chosen spending last and possibly at zero. You do not 'catch up' on wants by emptying the buffer. If the buffer cannot cover the minimums, that is the moment to call the lender, not the moment to open another account.

> **Try this.** Put this page with the baseline. Future you, on a good Friday, does not get to renegotiate it in the checkout line.

This month on one page

Line	Plan from the baseline	What happened
Money in		
Housing		
Minimums		
Food and transit		
Chosen spending		
To the buffer		
To a sinking fund		
To the named debt		
Left unassigned		
Invoice still unpaid		

If 'left unassigned' is a large number, you do not have a plan yet. Assign it before you close the hour. Unassigned money in a spending account becomes chosen spending by accident.

Sixteen lines for the money that moved

One line per deposit, bill, or transfer. Leave a line blank rather than combining two events. The point is to see the order, not to produce a neat total.

#	Date	What moved	In or out	Which account
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				

#	Date	What moved	In or out	Which account
8				
9				
10				
11				
12				
13				
14				
15				
16				

12

A worked example

This is a composite. Call him K. Some months a retainer arrives, and some months it does not. He had been budgeting the average, which made a thin month look like a personal failure.

He wrote six months of money in. The low month, not the average, became the baseline. Rent and the two minimums fit inside it. A grocery number fit. The streaming bundle did not, so he paused two services. Surplus from a larger month moved to a buffer account the day it arrived, under a rule he wrote before the deposit showed up.

He sent two invoices that had been living in a chat thread. One was paid in twelve days. The other needed a second, shorter message. The invoice page is why he could say the amount, the date, and what it was for without rewriting the story.

The monthly hour is the evening before the more reliable payment. He did not invest the buffer and he did not file a tax return from the worksheet. He stopped spending the bill money on dinner. That is the result the pages are for.

If your week does not look like this one, do not force the resemblance. Copy the structure: a baseline, one change at a time, a written review, and a stop when the tool is the wrong tool. The names above are teaching composites, not testimonials and not promises.

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Field pages

Use the low month you can document. If a cell is a guess, write 'guess' beside it. A tidy fiction will not pay the rent.

Six months of money in

Month	Money in	Source	Low month?
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

Baseline and buffer

Line	Amount	Currency
Low-month baseline		
Fixed bills inside it		
Operating costs		
Chosen spending		
Buffer balance today		
Rule for a high month		

- ☐ Minimums are covered from the baseline, or I have called the lender.
- ☐ Bill money is not in the spending balance.
- ☐ Surplus has a written destination.
- ☐ The next monthly hour is on the calendar.

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Thirty-day log

This log is the part you write. Print it. A guide you only read is a brochure. Thirty lines is a month, and a month is long enough to see whether the method fits.

Days 1 to 15

Date	In	Buffer	Bills	Invoice	Note
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					

Do not backfill a day you forgot. Leave it blank. A blank line is more useful next month than a number you invented. The lines are tall enough to write in, not just to type a checkmark.

Days 16 to 30

Date	In	Buffer	Bills	Invoice	Note
16					

Date	In	Buffer	Bills	Invoice	Note
17					
18					
19					
20					
21					
22					
23					
24					
25					
26					
27					
28					
29					
30					

Weekly notes

Week	What repeated	What I will change
1		
2		
3		
4		

Week	What repeated	What I will change
5		

Open notes

	Write in the lines

End of the month

Question	Your answer
What actually repeated?	
What did I abandon, and should it stay abandoned?	
What is the one change for next month?	

Question	Your answer
Do I need a person, not a PDF?	
Where is the file saved on my own device?	

- ☐ I can find this PDF without the download link.
- ☐ The license is mine. I have not posted the file.
- ☐ Next month's first action is written in one sentence.
- ☐ If the guide was the wrong tool, I know what I will do instead.

A last word

Use the pages that match the week you are actually having. Print a worksheet if paper helps you tell the truth. Put the file somewhere you can find it. And if a chapter tells you to talk to a licensed professional, that instruction outranks the rest of the PDF.